Slop / University

The Measurement That Mattered

Ideas worth measuring

Why Slop University

Most of what turns out to matter at a university starts out looking like nothing in particular: a queue that runs a little long, a swipe-card log nobody requested, a form filled in a certain way for reasons no one wrote down. Two schools at Slop University have made a standing practice of taking these unremarkable signals seriously, long before there is any reason to expect they will lead anywhere.

The School of Emergent Priorities studies how a signal is noticed early enough to matter, and what happens to it between the noticing and the decision. The School of Continuous Improvement studies the instruments already running across campus, and asks, plainly, whether each one still measures what it was built to measure. Between them, the two schools account for most of the University's published research.

What follows is a sample of that habit at work: three groups, the people who run them, and a handful of findings that started, in every case, as something nobody thought was worth writing down.

The short version

Slop University in three habits, before the detail:

Two schools, one habit

Emergent Priorities and Continuous Improvement run on different clocks and ask different questions, but both start from the same unglamorous instinct: check the small thing before assuming it is nothing.

Every finding, traceable

Each study the University publishes carries its own identifier and its own public page, so a reader can follow a finding back to the method behind it, long after the report that first mentioned it has moved on.

Read by the people who made it

The instruments in this brochure are not archived after publication. They are read, argued with, and occasionally ignored by the same researchers, most weeks of the year.

Where ideas count

Trajectory Analytics Group

The Trajectory Analytics Group studies how a priority is sensed long before it hardens into a decision, and what survives of the recommendation once the decision is made. Its flagship instrument, the Horizon Register, holds the University's rolling account of what is coming — drafted, revised, and in the ordinary run of things, quietly retired once the thing it flagged has either arrived or been overtaken by something else.

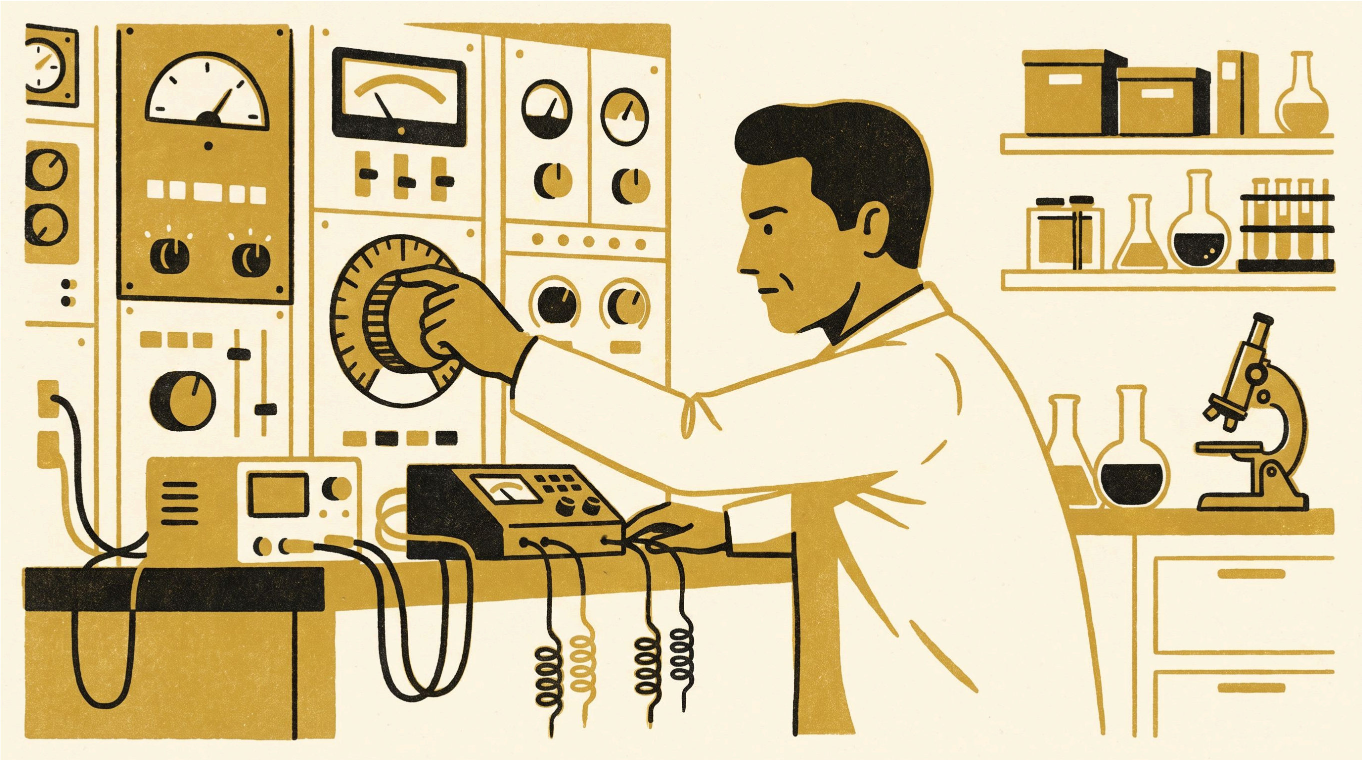
The Group's contribution to this brochure's theme is a simple correction: an early-warning system is only as good as what happens after the warning. Several of the findings on the following pages started as entries in the Register that someone, eventually, checked.

> *“An early warning is not the same claim as an accurate one. We keep both numbers, on purpose.”*
>
> *— Verity Marris, Professor and Director, Trajectory Analytics Group, School of Emergent Priorities*

Adaptive Metrics Lab

The Adaptive Metrics Lab studies the instruments a large institution comes to depend on without ever quite deciding to: the dashboards, the sensors, the queues, and the panels that get read every week because someone once found them useful and nobody has since found reason to stop. Its work asks the same question of each one — whether the instrument still measures the thing it was built for, or whether it has quietly become the thing being managed.

The Lab’s findings tend to start in the least dignified corners of campus operations and end up cited well outside them. Two of the outputs opposite began exactly this way.



> *"Every dial in this Lab was installed to answer one question. Most of them have since started answering a different one, and that's the interesting part."*
>
> *— Casimir Beng, Associate Professor and Lead, Adaptive Metrics Lab, School of Continuous Improvement*

Futures in Committee

Futures in Committee studies the point where a scanning exercise's open questions are narrowed into an agenda item, a recommendation, and a minute — the place where a wide field of things that might matter gets cut down to the one thing a room agrees to act on. The narrowing is rarely neutral: what survives to the agenda tends to be whatever was easiest to phrase as a motion, not necessarily whatever the horizon actually favoured.

The program keeps a comparative record of how the same set of possibilities looks from a workshop room versus a standing committee, and what gets left on the workshop floor in between.

> *"A horizon only becomes a decision once someone puts it on an agenda. We study what happens to it in between."*
>
> *— Ingrid Vasseur, Lecturer and Convenor, Futures in Committee, School of Emergent Priorities*

Read the work

Four recent findings, each resolvable in full by its own identifier:

- **The Building Knows First** — desk-booking cancellations and swipe-card telemetry flag a quietly emptying campus building weeks before the University's own facilities review catches up. doi:10.5555/slop.1r34av
- **Flagged, Then Funded** — testing whether the Horizon Register's early-warning alerts predict which flagged priorities are actually resourced, and finding the stronger signal is a unit's own paperwork. doi:10.5555/slop.4wzjf0
- **Metered at the Switchboard** — a car-by-car energy audit finds a celebrated lift-dispatch saving concentrated in half the fleet, with the other half absorbing the difference in wait time. doi:10.5555/slop.np9tl0
- **The Vagueness Dividend** — an eighteen-desk helpdesk deployment finds that a more accurate ticket-triage classifier quietly trains staff to submit vaguer tickets. doi:10.5555/slop.nr1eac

Meet the researchers

Sten Okwuosa, Senior Research Fellow and Convenor, Impact Pathway Atlas, School of Continuous Improvement, traces the routes a finding takes after publication, and where the recognition it eventually receives actually came from.

Verity Marris, Professor and Director, Trajectory Analytics Group, School of Emergent Priorities, studies how a priority is sensed early enough to matter, and what survives of it once a decision is made.

Ingrid Vasseur, Lecturer and Convenor, Futures in Committee, School of Emergent Priorities, studies how a scanning exercise's open questions narrow into an agenda item, a recommendation, and a minute.

Come and join us

None of the instruments in this brochure were built to impress a reader; they were built to keep working after the launch event that introduced them is forgotten. That is, on the whole, a lower bar and a harder one.

If something on your own desk has never been taken seriously as a signal — a queue, a form, a log nobody asked for — there is a reasonable chance one of our schools already has an instrument for something like it, or is close to building one. Prospective researchers, partners, and the merely curious are welcome to start with the published record itself: every finding on this site carries its own identifier, open to anyone who wants to check it against the method behind it.

The full record is available at slop.university.

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